

May 23, 2025

The Art of Unlearning: Lessons from Josh Waitzkin in the Age of AI

Jordi Visser

JVisser@22VResearch.com

22vresearch.com

“In the long run, the sharpest weapon of all is a kind of resilient adaptability.”

We all have songs that instantly transport us back to specific memories. For me, certain books do the same—and *The Art of Learning* by Josh Waitzkin is one of them. For those of you who don't know already, Josh was the child chess prodigy that served as the story for the 1980s movie, *Searching for Bobby Fischer*. I first read it in the aftermath of the Great Financial Crisis, a time when I was seeking out ideas that would challenge what I thought I knew and help me open my mind to the future. I recently referenced Daniel Pink's *A Whole New Mind*. It was another book that shaped my thinking about the brain, psychology and learning at the time. When I find a topic that fascinates me, I dig deep and back the, books were real time information. The 1990s were dubbed “the decade of the brain,” and the years that followed brought a wave of literature on learning, cognition, and adaptability. Among them all, Waitzkin's work stands out as the most impactful.

Years later, I wrote a paper titled *The Art of Unlearning*, where I argued that in a world defined by exponential change, true learning requires unlearning—an intentional process of letting go of outdated frameworks and remaining open to new ideas. Most people are trying to interpret the present at the speed of a bike, but we're now moving at 200 miles per hour—where the present and future blur together, and by the time you've made sense of 'now,' it's already behind you. To stay in the race, you have to unlearn as quickly as you learn—because anchoring to the past is the brake that keeps you from adapting in real time. This philosophy has guided my journey in using, analyzing, and imagining the future of AI and the profound ways it will transform our lives. It has also shaped my views on artificial intelligence's impact on economics, business cycles, and the future of capital structures. Waitzkin's book, often viewed as a manual for peak performance, offers something deeper: a framework for dismantling what we know to make space for what we need to learn next.

After achieving national fame as a chess prodigy, Josh Waitzkin made the unexpected decision to walk away from the game entirely. He shifted his focus to mastering a new discipline: the martial art of Tai Chi, specifically the competitive form known as push hands. It was a profound transition—not just between skills, but between mindsets. Tai Chi push hands is rooted in balance, adaptability, and sensing change in real time—making it a fitting analogy for how we must now engage with AI. Imagine riding the same escalator every day. You know its speed and rhythm. But one day, you step onto it and it accelerates dramatically. Your brain, conditioned by past experience, is unprepared. You lose balance. But if you had anticipated the change—if you had trained for unpredictability—your adjustment would be smoother. This is the world we now live in: an AI-driven economy where the rules are shifting faster than our cognitive defaults can process. In this environment, the ability to “learn how to learn” is no longer optional—it's a survival skill. And this kind of learning isn't additive; it's subtractive. It begins with letting go—of ego, of control, and of what we think we already know. For now, the acceleration of AI is easy to overlook because it's mostly happening in software. But that won't last. As AI becomes embodied—in humanoids, in full self-driving systems—the visual, physical presence of change will hit much harder. Preparing for that shift will challenge even the most adaptable among us. And more importantly, I don't believe you can truly understand the present—especially in markets and macroeconomics—without understanding AI.

“Growth comes at the point of resistance.”

Waitzkin makes it clear that true learning doesn't happen when everything is going well—it begins when we hit internal walls. In *The Art of Learning*, he shares how trying to apply his chess-trained precision to Tai Chi initially led to repeated failure. His muscle memory, rooted in logic and calculation, clashed with the fluid, reactive demands of a contact-based

martial art. But those failures weren't dead ends—they were thresholds. Each one exposed the limitations of his old knowledge and opened the door to something new.

This lesson has never been more relevant. As AI reshapes entire industries, professionals are discovering that what once made them successful may now hold them back. The marketer who relied on gut instinct must now master algorithmic targeting. The lawyer trained on precedent must now partner with predictive models. The doctor who memorized protocols must now work alongside diagnostic AI. These aren't just skill shifts—they're identity shifts. And they require the humility to face resistance, not as failure, but as a cue to evolve.

“We have to be willing to let go of our sense of knowing, to step into the unknown with humility.”

One of the greatest barriers to AI is not technical—it's psychological. It's one thing to talk about AI's potential, but it's another to personally confront what it asks of us: to begin again. For professionals who have spent years or decades mastering their field, this can feel like erasure. It's not just about learning a new tool. It's about stepping into unfamiliar territory without a map and accepting that what made you successful before may no longer apply.

Adoption requires the courage to start from zero. And it's precisely here that many get stuck—not because they lack the intelligence to understand AI, but because they resist the vulnerability of not being the expert anymore. As Waitzkin reminds us, the beginner's mindset isn't a weakness—it's a superpower. Children learn quickly because they haven't yet hardened around fixed beliefs—they're open, curious, and unafraid of failure. Their brains are wired for experimentation, not preservation. In a time of exponential change, we must cultivate that same openness. The ability to adopt is the ability to let go. The ones who thrive will not be those who cling to expertise, but those who embrace the humility of starting over.

“Making smaller circles.”

Waitzkin's concept of “making smaller circles” is about simplifying without losing depth—distilling complex ideas into internalized, intuitive knowledge. This doesn't happen quickly. He emphasizes a long-term, organic process of transformation—slow, often invisible progress made through repetition and refinement. In an era dominated by AI, this lesson feels countercultural.

The speed of AI adoption tempts us to look for quick hacks or plug-and-play solutions. But meaningful fluency in AI—true integration—requires time and curiosity. It's not enough to prompt a model. We must understand why it responds the way it does, how data moves through it, and where its limitations lie. This is pattern recognition over time. It's learning how to think with machines, not just use them. Waitzkin's call to deepen, rather than rush, offers a blueprint for developing AI intuition in a world obsessed with shortcuts.

“Learn the macro from the micro.”

Waitzkin discovered that letting go of structured systems and embracing spontaneity was essential to his growth. In Tai Chi, this meant responding to force not with force, but with flow—meeting tension with softness. This looseness, once a weakness in his mind, became a strength. He learned to trust in responsiveness over rigidity.

The same lesson applies in the age of AI. These systems are probabilistic, not rule-based. They work best when guided, not commanded. Analysts, teachers, and business leaders who cling to linear thinking—who expect tidy inputs to produce tidy outputs—struggle with AI. Success comes not from control, but from calibration. From testing, iterating, adjusting. The professionals who thrive are those who embrace the ambiguity, not resist it. Just like Waitzkin, they learn that flexibility—not precision—is what leads to mastery in complex systems.

There is where AI excels. As an example of attacking the impact of AI to economics and the argument I make about recessions not existing, let's use Okun's Law as something to use AI to learn flexibility. Okun's Law has long been a foundational concept in macroeconomics because it provides a simple, intuitive link between growth and employment. It suggests that when the economy grows faster than its potential, unemployment falls, and when growth slows, joblessness rises. Policymakers have used it for decades to estimate how much GDP growth is needed to bring down unemployment rates or, conversely, to gauge how a slowdown might impact the labor market. It's been a key tool for forecasting recessions, setting interest rates, and designing fiscal stimulus.

So here is a simple Q&A I will do with ChatGPT-

Q: Does Okun's Law still hold in a world of AI-driven productivity?

A: *Not in the way it used to. Okun's Law is built on the assumption that economic growth and employment are tightly linked—that you need more workers to produce more output. But AI breaks that relationship. As machines and algorithms increasingly perform tasks once handled by humans, we can now generate more economic output without increasing labor—and in some cases, while reducing it. This means GDP can rise even as employment stagnates. In an AI-driven economy, productivity gains are no longer necessarily tied to job creation. Instead, they are increasingly tied to capital investment in technology, data infrastructure, and software—decoupling growth from traditional labor dynamics. In this way, AI doesn't just change how we work—it challenges the very models we've used to understand the economy for decades.*

And now another-

Q: Has labor flexibility changed since the rise of the smartphone?

A: *Dramatically. The smartphone, combined with cloud software and communication tools, has untethered work from fixed locations and traditional hours. This shift gave rise to the gig economy, remote work, and a new class of contingent labor. Today, businesses can scale labor up or down with far greater speed and precision than in past economic cycles. This flexibility dampens the traditional signals of downturns—like mass layoffs or unemployment spikes—because companies can trim hours, shift to freelancers, or automate tasks rather than eliminate full-time jobs. In this way, the smartphone era has redefined labor dynamics, contributing to why recessions may appear softer or more fragmented in data, even when structural adjustments are underway.*

“The obstacle is the path.”

Perhaps the most difficult part of unlearning is the emotional toll. Waitzkin built his identity around mastery—first in chess, then in structured thought. Stepping into a more chaotic martial discipline forced him to not only rebuild technique but to confront the ego built on expertise. For many navigating today's AI transition, this feels familiar.

Credentials, status, and institutional knowledge are being disrupted by technologies that can outperform humans in narrow domains. That sense of loss—of status, of control, of predictability—is real. But it's not the end of value; it's the beginning of reinvention. As Waitzkin learned, embracing chaos doesn't mean giving up—it means evolving. And it's in that discomfort that our most human capabilities—creativity, intuition, judgment—can reemerge with new power.

“The art of learning is to become resilient, not perfect.”

Waitzkin's final and perhaps most essential message is this: learning is not about flawless execution—it's about durable transformation. It's not a ladder you climb, but a cycle you move through again and again. In the AI era, this perspective is liberating. No one will master it all. Tools will evolve, systems will break, paradigms will shift.

What matters most is resilience—the ability to begin again without ego, to update without fear, and to approach each iteration with curiosity. We're entering a future where every form of expertise will be tested. But if we adopt the mindset Waitzkin models—humble, open, resilient—we'll remain capable not only of surviving disruption, but of thriving within it.

DISCLOSURES AND DISCLAIMERS

Analyst Certification

The analyst, 22V Research Group, primarily responsible for the preparation of this research report attests to the following: (1) that the views and opinions rendered in this research report reflect his or her personal views about the subject companies or issuers; and (2) that no part of the research analyst's compensation was, is, or will be directly related to the specific recommendations or views in this research report.

Analyst Certifications and Independence of Research.

Each of the 22V Research analysts whose names appear on the front page of this report hereby certify that all the views expressed in this Report accurately reflect our personal views about any and all of the subject securities or issuers and that no part of our compensation was, is, or will be, directly or indirectly, related to the specific recommendations or views of in this Report.

22V Research (the "Company") is an independent research provider. The Company is not a member of the FINRA or the SIPC and is not a registered broker dealer or investment adviser. 22V Research has no other regulated or unregulated business activities which conflict with its provision of independent research.

22V Research, LLC is a professional services and independent publication organization. 22V Research, LLC is not a securities broker-dealer, not a member of the Financial Industry Regulatory Authority (FINRA), not a registered investment advisor (RIA) and not a member of SIPC.

Securities transactions, when offered, are offered by 22V Securities, LLC through LPS Capital, LLC. Certain employees of 22V Securities, LLC are dually registered as securities representatives of LPS Capital, LLC or Analyst Hub Securities, LLC. 22V Securities, LPS Capital and Analyst Hub Securities are members FINRA, SIPC.

<https://brokercheck.finra.org/>

Current Ratings Definition.

SECTOR OUTPERFORM: An "outperform" rating anticipates the company will outperform the S&P Regional Banking Index (peer group).

SECTOR PERFORM: A "market perform" rating anticipates the company will perform in line with the S&P Regional Banking Index (peer group).

SECTOR UNDERPERFORM: An "underperform" rating anticipates the company will underperform the S&P Regional Banking Index (peer group).

Limitation Of Research And Information.

This Report has been prepared for distribution to only qualified institutional or professional clients of 22V Research Group. The contents of this Report represent the views, opinions, and analyses of its authors. The information contained herein does not constitute financial, legal, tax or any other advice. All third-party data presented herein were obtained from publicly available sources which are believed to be reliable; however, the Company makes no warranty, express or implied, concerning the accuracy or completeness of such information. In no event shall the Company be responsible or liable for the correctness of, or update to, any such material or for any damage or lost opportunities resulting from use of this data. Nothing contained in this Report or any distribution by the Company should be construed as any offer to sell, or any solicitation of an offer to buy, any security or investment. Any research or other material received should not be construed as individualized investment advice. Investment decisions should be made as part of an overall portfolio strategy and you should consult with a professional financial advisor, legal and tax advisor prior to making any investment decision. 22V Research Group shall not be liable for any direct or indirect, incidental or consequential loss or damage (including loss of profits, revenue or goodwill) arising from any investment decisions based on information or research obtained from 22V Research Group.

Reproduction And Distribution Strictly Prohibited.

No user of this Report may reproduce, modify, copy, distribute, sell, resell, transmit, transfer, license, assign or publish the Report itself or any information contained therein. Notwithstanding the foregoing, clients with access to working models are permitted to alter or modify the information contained therein, provided that it is solely for such client's own use. This Report is not intended to be available or distributed for any purpose that would be deemed unlawful or otherwise prohibited by any local, state, national or international laws or regulations or would otherwise subject the Company to registration or regulation of any kind within such jurisdiction.

Copyrights, Trademarks, Intellectual Property.

22V Research Group, and any logos or marks included in this Report are proprietary materials. The use of such terms and logos and marks without the express written consent of 22V Research Group is strictly prohibited. The copyright in the pages or in the screens of the Report, and in the information and material therein, is proprietary material owned by 22V Research Group unless otherwise indicated. The unauthorized use of any material on this Report may violate numerous statutes, regulations and laws, including, but not limited to, copyright, trademark, trade secret or patent laws.